THE MODERN MAN'S GROOMING KIT

↘ VITAMIN C SERUM

Brightens dull skin, fades spots and adds a glow

Average cost: ₹500–₹800

Minimalist Vitamin C 10% Face Serum is a common starter

↘ LIGHT WEIGHT GEL MOISTURISER

Hydrates without greasiness, works under sunscreen or makeup

Average cost: ₹300–₹600

POND'S Super Light Gel Oil-Free Moisturiser is a hyaluronic acid gel, popular with influencers



↘ SUNSCREEN (SPF 50+)

Protects against tanning, pigmentation and premature ageing; now a non-negotiable step

Average cost: ₹400–₹800

Aqualogica Glow+ Dewy Sunscreen SPF 50+ PA++++ is a vitamin C and papaya sunscreen that protects without a white cast

↘ CLEAR BROW GEL

Tidies eyebrows and subtly frames the face; doubles as a beard-line groomer in some routines

Average cost: ₹1,500–2,800

Benefit Cosmetics 24-hr Brow Setter Clear Brow Gel grooms brows without obvious colour

↘ BLEMISH GEL

Evens out skin tone and blurs marks while still looking natural

Average cost: ₹400–₹1,000

Charlotte Tilbury Unisex Healthy Glow is a sheer, bronzy tint marketed as a one-step glow for all genders



build credibility without large celebrity endorsements at the outset.

Not anymore. The stigma has been thinning. "Makeup for men is going to be mainstream," says skincare influencer Sunny Valmiki. "Grooming is becoming genderless." According to 35-year-old Akshat Kapoor, a Delhi-based communications professional, grooming for men is not a new concept in India. "The Maharajas and Mughals were all very indulgent men. Sometime when the British came, the whole concept of masculinity changed. Any man who went to the salon would be considered effeminate. Then came the metrosexual men who looked for a certain upkeep. That is the driving force for us today." Younger men, says Ishendra Agarwal, founder of the jewellery brand Giva, have become an easier demographic to sell to. Giva has a separate section on its website for men. "Gen-Z and millennials see jewellery as self-expression, not status. Men today want pieces that fit their personality instead of their gender," says Agarwal, adding that many men now buy everyday pieces rather than just wedding sets. In a reel posted by 21-year-old Rohan S., a Mumbai-based jewellery designer based in Mumbai, you see him in a plain white tee and straight-fit jeans, slipping on a sterling-silver chain, a single ring and a slim cuff. His caption—'You don't need to be a rapper to wear jewellery'.



" INDIAN MEN ARE RAISED WITH A RIGID BLUEPRINT OF MASCULINITY. ANYTHING SOFT LIKE GROOMING OR JEWELLERY IS SEEN AS WEAKNESS. YOUNGER MEN ARE QUESTIONING THAT "

DR SRIKANTH SRINIVASAN
Chief Medical Director, Niyama Digital Healthcare

NOW HERS AND HIS

Even brands once designated as feminine are rewriting their marketing. Clovia, once known for women's lingerie, now sells men's innerwear and nightwear. Skincare brands that sold rose lotions exclusively for women now package the same fragrances in minimal, unisex bottles. The boundary between 'his products' and 'her products' is dissolving on shelves and screens. Across the country, rose-scented scrubs, rose water mists, jasmine body washes, sandal-and-rose oils and floral foot rituals are becoming part of men's weekend spa routines. Urban Company, which once only had at-home beauty services for women, now has a dedicated men's grooming vertical that offers beard sculpting, anti-pollution facials, Swedish massages, foot spas, foot steaming, de-tan masks, body polishing and brightening pedicures involving masks, scrubs and long reflexology massages. At Looks Salon, the gents' menu includes clarifying facials, blackhead extraction, manicures, pedicures, brow grooming and grey-blending hair colour. High-end spas offer signature rituals specifically 'for men & women'.

Feeding the male fixation with beauty is a thriving influencer ecosystem on social media. Open the Explore tab on Instagram and search for male grooming, and you enter a universe where men are not merely experimenting with cosmetics but are strikingly fluent in them. A 10-second scroll and you find creators deftly blending blemish gel, applying concealer,